

A 16-WEEK LIFESTYLE & NUTRITION PLAN



PANDA's Program

Eat more. Train smart. Walk daily. Build the body — don't shrink it.

Real food, real flavour, real portions — designed around Tunisian & Syrian cooking, a student's timetable, and a Madrid supermarket.
Halal throughout.

BUILT FOR

Panda

MADRID

59 KG → 55 KG · 16 WEEKS

READ THIS PAGE TWICE

Why you have no energy, aren't losing fat, and *are* losing muscle

All three of those complaints have the same single cause, and it isn't the one you think. You are not eating too much. You are eating far too little, for far too long — and almost no protein at all.

WHAT YOUR BODY DID ABOUT IT

When food stays scarce for months, the body doesn't "burn fat faster". It protects itself. It turns the thermostat down: less heat, less spontaneous movement, slower digestion, foggier head, colder hands, flatter mood.

And because it still needs amino acids every single day to repair skin, hair, hormones and immune cells, and you aren't eating any, it takes them from the only store you have — your muscle. That is the tissue you are losing.

WHY THE SCALE STOPPED MOVING

A body burning less and moving less needs less. Your maintenance drifted down until it met the tiny amount you were eating. That's the stall.

Meanwhile muscle is the tissue that burns calories at rest. Every kilo you lose makes the problem worse. That's why eating even less has stopped working — and why it will never work again.

The fix is not less food. It's more — and better built.

THE WHOLE PROGRAM IN ONE SENTENCE

Eat **three real meals every day**, put **protein in every one of them**, keep walking, go to Pilates three times a week, and sleep — and your body will let go of fat instead of muscle, because for the first time it can afford to.

Three things to accept before week 1

- 1 You will eat more than you have in a year.**
Roughly 1,900 kcal a day for the first three weeks. That is not a lot — it's normal. It only feels enormous because you've been running on half of it.
- 2 The scale may go *up* in weeks 1–3.**
By 0.5–1.5 kg. It is water, glycogen and food in your gut — the three things that refill when you start eating. It is physically impossible for it to be fat at these calories. Do not panic and do not cut.
- 3 Nothing here is "clean eating".**
There is bread, rice, olive oil, merguez, dates and dark chocolate in this document. You already cook better than most people ever will. The only things missing were *quantity* and *protein*.

THE TARGETS

Your numbers

1.60_m

HEIGHT

59_{kg}

STARTING WEIGHT

55_{kg}

GOAL WEIGHT

16_{wk}

TIMELINE

WHAT YOUR BODY BURNS

At complete rest (BMR)

≈ 1,330 kcal

+ daily living, 6–10k steps

≈ +450 kcal

+ Pilates, 3 × 60 min

≈ +130 kcal

Your maintenance

≈ 1,900–1,950

Which means eating 1,000–1,200 kcal a day, as you have been, puts you 800 kcal under — every day. That is starvation territory, and the body responds accordingly.

WHAT YOU’LL ACTUALLY EAT

Weeks 1–3

Phase 1 · Refuel

1,900 kcal

115 g protein

Weeks 4–16

Phase 2 · Reshape

1,700 kcal

120 g protein

A deficit of about 250 kcal a day. Small on purpose: big deficits burn muscle, kill energy and wreck adherence. Small deficits + high protein + resistance work do the opposite.

Phase 2 macros — what 1,700 kcal is made of

MACRO	GRAMS / DAY	CALORIES	WHY THIS AMOUNT
Protein	120 g	480	2 g per kg. This is the single number that decides whether you lose fat or muscle. Non-negotiable.
Fat	55 g	495	Olive oil, eggs, tahini, nuts, feta. Needed for hormones and for your period to stay regular.
Carbs	180 g	725	Bread, rice, bulgur, fruit, dates. This is your energy and your Pilates fuel. Not the enemy.

DON’T CHASE 55.0 ON THE SCALE

You are going to lose roughly 4 kg of fat *and* add 1–1.5 kg of muscle. If the scale stops at 56 kg, you will look like someone who lost six. Muscle takes up far less room than fat for the same weight — so the tape measure and your jeans will tell the truth long before the scale agrees. Track the waist.

NON - NEGOTIABLES

The seven rules

If you forget everything else in this document, keep these. They do 90 % of the work.

1 Three meals. Every day. No exceptions.

Breakfast, lunch, dinner — even a small one, even late, even when you're not hungry. Skipping a meal is what taught your body to slow down. Twenty-one meals a week is the habit that reverses it. A four-minute plate of tuna, chickpeas, olive oil and lemon counts as a meal. Nothing does not.

2 Protein first, at every single meal

Build each plate around the protein, then add the rest. **BREAKFAST 30 G** **LUNCH 40-45 G**
DINNER 30 G **SNACKS 15-20 G** Protein is the only macro that signals your body to keep — and add — muscle while losing fat. It also keeps you full for hours, which is why you will stop crashing at 3 p.m.

3 Never go below 1,600 kcal

Not on a busy day, not on a bad day, not to "make up" for yesterday. Below that line you are back in the exact hole this program exists to get you out of. There is no version of this where eating less makes it faster.

4 Season everything properly

Harissa, garlic, cumin, sumac, lemon, olive oil, fresh parsley and mint. Flavour costs almost no calories and it is the entire reason this will still be running in week 12. Bland food is not healthier — it is just food you will stop eating.

5 2-2.5 litres of water a day

Half a litre the moment you wake up, before coffee. A bottle in your bag for class. A large part of the tiredness you feel at 11 a.m. is simply that you haven't drunk anything since yesterday.

6 Lights out by 22:30

You wake at 6:00. That's 7.5 hours. Muscle is built and appetite hormones are reset during sleep — short sleep raises hunger, lowers willpower and blunts every gain from the Pilates studio. Phone on the other side of the room.

7 Walk, every day, whatever else happens

6,000-10,000 steps. Steps are the quiet engine of this whole plan: they burn more over a week than any workout would, they cost you no recovery, and they don't make you hungry the way cardio does. They happen on Pilates days too.

ORGANISATION

The weekday, hour by hour

Class 08:00–12:00, home at 13:00. Everything below is built around that. Read it once, then stop thinking about it — the point of a routine is that it stops needing decisions.

06:00 ● Wake · 500 ml of water

Before anything else, before the phone. A full glass with a squeeze of lemon and a pinch of salt. You've had nothing to drink for eight hours — this alone removes half the morning fog.

06:15 ● Breakfast · 10 minutes, 30 g protein

The most important change in this entire program. Six options on the next pages; the fastest takes 90 seconds. **Coffee comes after food, never before** — coffee on an empty stomach is a big part of why you feel shaky and nauseous and then can't face eating.

07:00 ○ Bag check

Water bottle, and the mid-morning snack you packed last night. Ten seconds. Do not leave it to the morning — morning - you will skip it.

07:20 ○ Leave · walk part of the way

Get off one metro stop early, or walk the first stretch. 1,500–2,500 steps banked before 8 a.m., with zero effort and no extra time if you leave five minutes earlier.

10:00 ○ Mid-morning snack · 15–20 g protein

Between lectures, from your bag. This is what stops you arriving home at 13:00 starving, exhausted and ready to eat nothing at all. Six options on page 9.

13:15 ● Lunch · the big meal of the day

40–45 g protein, a proper portion of carbs, real cooking. You're home, you have time, and your appetite is highest — so this is where the biggest meal goes. 15–25 minutes, cooked fresh.

16:30 ○ Pilates (on class days)

Never fasted. Lunch at 13:15 is your fuel; if the class is later than 17:30, take the afternoon snack first. Protein within about two hours after.

17:30 ○ Afternoon snack

Fruit and nuts, or yogurt, or a shake. Keeps dinner from becoming a raid on the kitchen.

20:15 ● Dinner · light, 30 g protein, ≤ 15 min

Soup, mezze plate, eggs, grilled fish, big salad. Warm, comforting and small. Eight options on pages 14–15, three of which need no cooking at all.

21:15 ○ Optional sweet fix + mint tea

Planned, not stolen. Two dates and yogurt, or 20 g of dark chocolate. This is in the budget.

21:40 ○ Two minutes of prep for tomorrow

Pack the snack. Boil three eggs if you're having them. Put the whey scoop in the shaker. That is the entire "meal prep" this program asks of you.

22:30 ● Lights out

7.5 hours before a 6:00 alarm. Screens down at 21:45.

WEEKENDS & DAYS OFF

The structure stays, the clock moves. Wake later, but still eat three times — the two habits that break programs are "I woke up at 11 so I skipped breakfast" and "I'll just eat once today". Family meals are welcome: take a normal plate, add protein where you can, and skip the second round of bread.

THE ARCHITECTURE

How a day adds up

You never have to count anything. Pick one item from each row below and the day lands on target by itself — that is the whole point of the menus.

MEAL	TIME	CALORIES	PROTEIN	WHERE TO FIND IT
Breakfast	06:15	400–480	28–34 g	6 options · pages 7–8
Mid-morning	10:00	200–250	13–26 g	6 options · page 9
Lunch	13:15	600–650	34–48 g	8 options · pages 10–12
Afternoon	17:30	120–180	0–15 g	7 options · page 16
Dinner	20:15	380–450	28–38 g	8 options · pages 13–15
DAY TOTAL		≈ 1,900	115–145 g	Phase 1 · weeks 1–3

Turning Phase 1 into Phase 2 — change three things, nothing else

From week 4 you drop about 200 kcal a day. You do *not* drop a meal, and you do not touch the protein or the olive oil. You shave the starch slightly, in three places:

–80 KCAL

Lunch grain

160 g cooked rice / bulgur → **100 g**. Roughly one heaped serving spoon less. Fill the gap on the plate with more salad.

–70 KCAL

Breakfast starch

Two slices of bread → **one**, or 45 g of oats → **30 g**. Same eggs, same yogurt, same nuts.

–60 KCAL

Afternoon snack

Choose from the **≤ 150 kcal** half of the snack list instead of the larger ones. You still snack. Every day.

WHY PHASE 1 EXISTS AT ALL

Three weeks of eating at maintenance before any deficit. It refills glycogen, restores your thyroid and appetite signalling, brings your energy back and gets the three-meal habit locked in. Cutting from a starved baseline is how people lose muscle and stall by week five. We are not doing that. **In weeks 1–3, success is 21 days of three meals — not a number on the scale.**

TWO RULES FOR READING THE MENUS

- Weights are the **raw** weight of meat and fish, and the **cooked** weight of grains, unless stated.
- Anything marked ★ is a “worst day” option — fastest to make, hardest to talk yourself out of. Learn those four first and the rest is decoration.

06:15 · 30 G PROTEIN · 10 MINUTES

Breakfast

This is the meal that changes everything else. Eating 30 g of protein before 7 a.m. is what kills the 11 a.m. shakiness, the 3 p.m. collapse and the evening over-hunger — all three, within about ten days. Pick one, make it, eat it sitting down. **Coffee after, not before.**

B1 Express Shakshuka ★

10 MIN

YOU NEED

- 3 eggs
- 200 g tinned crushed tomato (half a tin)
- ½ onion or ½ green pepper, sliced thin
- 1 tsp harissa · ½ tsp cumin · salt
- 1 tsp olive oil
- 1 small wholemeal pita (60 g)

METHOD

Oil in a small pan on high. Onion or pepper, 3 minutes. Tomato, harissa, cumin and salt, 3 minutes more until it thickens. Crack the eggs straight in, lid on, 4 minutes.

Eat it out of the pan with the pita. One pan to wash.

455 KCAL **27 g** PROTEIN

Sunday, cook the tomato base for four portions in one pot and keep it in a jar. That isn't meal prep — it's a sauce in the fridge. Breakfast then takes four minutes.

B2 Labneh, Za'atar & Egg Toast

6 MIN

YOU NEED

- 2 slices wholemeal or rye bread (70 g)
- 4 tbsp labneh (80 g), or thick Greek yogurt
- Za'atar + 1 tsp olive oil
- 3 eggs, boiled 8 min *the night before*
- Cherry tomatoes, cucumber, olives

METHOD

Toast the bread. Spread the labneh thick, pour the oil over, rain za'atar on top. Peel the eggs, halve them, salt and black pepper.

Tomatoes and cucumber on the side. Done before the kettle boils.

470 KCAL **30 g** PROTEIN

Boil six eggs at once on Sunday and Wednesday evening. They keep a week in the fridge and they are the single most useful thing you can have in there.

B3 The Two-Minute Yogurt Bowl ★

2 MIN

YOU NEED

- 200 g Greek yogurt 2 % — or a 150 g skyr pot
- 30 g oats
- 1 tsp honey, or 2 dates chopped in
- 15 g walnuts, almonds or pistachios
- Cinnamon · a little grated apple or banana

METHOD

Yogurt in a bowl. Everything else on top. Stir once. Eat.

If you want it warmer and more filling: 30 seconds in the microwave for the oats with a splash of milk first, then the yogurt on top.

440 KCAL **28 g** PROTEIN

With skyr instead of Greek yogurt this hits 33 g of protein for the same calories. Skyr is the best-value protein in any Spanish supermarket.

B4 Feta & Tomato Scramble Wrap

7 MIN

YOU NEED

- 3 eggs
- 30 g feta, crumbled
- ½ tomato, diced · handful of parsley or mint
- 1 wholemeal tortilla (60 g)
- Black pepper · sumac · 1 tsp olive oil

METHOD

Beat the eggs with pepper. Low heat, oil, eggs — stir slowly and take them off while still slightly wet. Fold the feta, tomato and herbs in off the heat so the feta softens but doesn't melt away.

Pile into the tortilla, sumac over the top, roll it, eat it walking if you must.

480 KCAL **30 g** PROTEIN

The only breakfast here that survives being carried. Wrap it in foil and eat it at 8:30 in the corridor if you overslept.

B5 Overnight Oats, Syrian Style

3 MIN THE NIGHT BEFORE

YOU NEED

- 45 g oats
- 200 ml semi-skimmed milk
- 1 scoop whey (30 g), or 100 g Greek yogurt
- 1 tsp tahini + 1 tsp honey
- Cinnamon + a pinch of cardamom
- 8 pistachios, chopped, on top

METHOD

Everything except the pistachios into a jar. Shake. Fridge. Go to bed.

In the morning: pistachios on top, spoon, done. Zero minutes of morning effort, which makes it the best option for the days you know you'll be rushing.

470 KCAL **34 g** PROTEIN

Tahini + cinnamon + cardamom is what makes this taste like halawa rather than like a diet. Don't skip the tahini.

B6 The 90-Second Emergency ★

90 SEC

YOU NEED

- 1 scoop whey (30 g)
- 250 ml semi-skimmed milk
- 1 banana
- 20 g almonds, eaten on the side

METHOD

Shaker. Milk, then powder. Shake for ten seconds. Drink it. Eat the banana and the almonds on the way out.

This exists so that "I didn't have time" stops being a reason to skip breakfast. There is no morning on earth that doesn't have ninety seconds in it.

420 KCAL **33 g** PROTEIN

This is the floor, not the habit. Maximum twice a week — liquid food doesn't satisfy you the way a plate does.

"BUT I'M NEVER HUNGRY IN THE MORNING"

Expected, and temporary. Your stomach has adapted to being empty and your hunger hormones have gone quiet — that's a symptom of the problem, not a preference. For the first five days use **B6**, which is drinkable and asks nothing of your appetite. Then move to B3, then to the cooked ones. Real morning hunger usually comes back within ten to fourteen days of eating regularly, and when it does, it's one of the clearest signs that your metabolism is waking up.

10:00 · IN YOUR BAG · PACKED THE NIGHT BEFORE

The mid-morning snack

Small job, enormous effect. This is the thing standing between “I got home at one o'clock and couldn't face cooking” and a proper lunch. Pack it at **22:00**, not at 06:00 — morning - you will forget it, every time.

20 G PROTEIN

Skyr pot + almonds

150 g skyr · 15 g almonds

The default. Needs no container, no preparation, survives a warm bag for a few hours. Buy six on Sunday.

210 kcal

13 G PROTEIN

Two boiled eggs + an apple

2 eggs boiled 8 min · 1 apple · salt in a twist of foil

Cheapest option on the page. Peel them the night before if you don't want to do it between lectures.

230 kcal

18 G PROTEIN

Cottage cheese + dates

150 g *queso batido* or requesón · 2 Medjool dates · cinnamon

Tastes like dessert, behaves like protein. The cinnamon is not optional — it's what makes plain cottage cheese pleasant.

200 kcal

26 G PROTEIN

Pre-dosed shaker + banana

Dry whey in the shaker · add water at uni · 1 banana

Highest protein, zero weight, zero refrigeration. Put the powder in the shaker the night before and it becomes a thirty-second job.

230 kcal

20 G PROTEIN

Turkey, cheese & a pear

60 g sliced halal turkey · 1 portion cheese · 1 pear

Buy the turkey from the halal counter or a certified brand — most Spanish *fiambre* is pork, so read the label rather than the picture.

250 kcal

8 G PROTEIN

Hummus, carrots & pita

60 g hummus · carrot and cucumber sticks · 30 g pita

The lowest-protein option here, so pair it with a yogurt — or save it for a day when lunch is one of the 45 g ones.

220 kcal

THE SUNDAY SHOP, IN ONE LINE

Six skyr pots, a dozen eggs, a bag of almonds, a bag of apples or pears. That is every mid-morning snack for the week, bought in ninety seconds, and it removes the decision entirely.

13:15 · 40–45 G PROTEIN · THE BIG MEAL

Lunch

You're home, your appetite is highest, and you have the afternoon — so the biggest meal of the day goes here. Nothing takes more than 25 minutes, and most take under 20.

L1 Chicken Shawarma Bowl ★

20 MIN

YOU NEED

- 160 g chicken thigh or breast, cut in strips
- *Marinade*: 2 tbsp yogurt · ½ lemon · 1 clove garlic · 1 tsp baharat · salt
- 160 g cooked rice or bulgur (100 g in Phase 2)
- Tomato, cucumber, red onion, parsley, sumac
- *Sauce*: 1 tbsp tahini + water + lemon + garlic

METHOD

Marinate in the bowl you'll eat from while the rice cooks — ten minutes is plenty, it doesn't need an hour. Then: pan as hot as you dare, no crowding, 8 minutes, don't stir constantly. You want dark edges.

Rice down, chicken on top, salad beside, tahini loosened with cold water over everything.

640 KCAL **46 g** PROTEIN

The one to learn first. Change only the spice and it becomes four different meals — see the box on page 12.

L2 Ojja Merguez

15 MIN

YOU NEED

- 2 halal merguez (100 g), sliced thick — or 120 g halal chicken sausage
- 1 green pepper, sliced · 2 tomatoes or ½ tin crushed
- 2 eggs
- 1 tsp harissa · 1 tsp tabil or cumin · 2 cloves garlic
- 60 g bread, for mopping

METHOD

Merguez in a dry pan first — it gives up its own fat and you cook everything else in it. Three minutes, then pepper and garlic, three more. Tomato, harissa and tabil in, and let it reduce properly — 5 minutes, until it stops being watery.

Two wells, two eggs, lid on, 3–4 minutes. Yolks still soft. Bread.

620 KCAL **38 g** PROTEIN

Merguez is fatty, which is why the portion is 100 g and why there's no added oil. It's in the budget — enjoy it once or twice a week.

L3 Kefta & Bulgur

20 MIN

YOU NEED

- 150 g beef mince 5 % fat
- ½ onion grated · large handful parsley · 1 tsp cumin · ½ tsp paprika · salt, pepper
- 150 g cooked bulgur or freekeh (100 g in Phase 2)
- *Cucumber yogurt*: 120 g Greek yogurt, grated cucumber, dried mint, garlic

METHOD

Bulgur on — 12 minutes, no attention. Squeeze the water out of the grated onion first or the patties fall apart. Mix the mince with everything, shape four small flat patties, hot pan, 4 minutes a side.

Yogurt sauce stirred together while they cook. Everything on one plate.

630 KCAL **47 g** PROTEIN

Highest-iron meal in the book. Put it in the week your period is due — you lose iron then, and low iron is the most common cause of exactly the tiredness you've been describing.

L4 Lablabi Bowl**12 MIN****YOU NEED**

- 1 tin chickpeas (240 g drained)
- 3 cloves garlic, crushed · 1 tsp cumin · stock or water
- 2 eggs, soft-boiled or poached
- 1 tbsp harissa · 1 tbsp olive oil · juice of ½ lemon
- 40 g day-old bread, torn
- Parsley, capers, olives, a little raw onion

METHOD

Chickpeas into a small pan with just enough water to cover, the garlic and the cumin. Simmer 8 minutes until the garlic has gone soft and sweet.

Torn bread into the bottom of a deep bowl. Ladle the chickpeas and their broth over it.

Eggs on top, then harissa, olive oil, lemon, and everything green and salty you have.

610 KCAL **34 g** PROTEIN

Costs about €1.50 and takes twelve minutes. The meat-free day that doesn't feel like a meat-free day.

L5 Salmon & Batata Harra**25 MIN (20 HANDS-OFF)****YOU NEED**

- 150 g salmon fillet
- 250 g potatoes, cut in 2 cm cubes
- 1 tbsp olive oil · smoked paprika · 3 cloves garlic · chilli · big handful coriander
- Lemon · salt
- Green salad on the side

METHOD

Oven 210 °C. Potatoes tossed with the oil, paprika and salt, on the tray, 20 minutes.

At 12 minutes, push them aside and put the salmon on the same tray, skin down, lemon and salt on it.

Out of the oven: garlic, chilli and coriander through the hot potatoes so they cook in the residual heat and stay sharp. Lemon over everything.

650 KCAL **36 g** PROTEIN

Twenty of the twenty-five minutes are the oven working alone — put it in, then go and do something else. One tray to wash.

L6 Tuna Fattoush Plus ★**10 MIN · NO COOKING****YOU NEED**

- 2 tins tuna in olive oil, drained (160 g)
- 120 g tinned chickpeas
- Romaine, tomato, cucumber, radish, spring onion
- Mint and parsley, a lot of both
- *Dressing:* olive oil, lemon, 1 tsp sumac, garlic, salt
- 1 pita, toasted hard and broken over the top

METHOD

Pita in the toaster until it snaps. Everything else chopped rough into one big bowl.

Dressing shaken in a cup, poured over, tossed hard with your hands so the sumac coats everything.

Broken pita over the top *last*, or it goes soft.

600 KCAL **45 g** PROTEIN

The worst-day lunch. No hob, no oven, ten minutes, 45 g of protein. Keep the tuna and chickpeas permanently stocked so this is always possible.

L7 Harissa Chicken Pasta

15 MIN

YOU NEED

- 70 g dry wholewheat pasta (55 g in Phase 2)
- 140 g chicken breast, diced small
- 200 g crushed tomato · 1 tsp harissa · 2 cloves garlic
- 20 g grated cheese · basil or parsley · 1 tsp olive oil

METHOD

Pasta on. While it cooks: chicken in a hot oiled pan, 5 minutes, salt it at the end not the start.

Garlic 30 seconds, harissa 30 seconds, tomato in, simmer while the pasta finishes.

Drain the pasta but keep a splash of the water — it's what makes the sauce cling. Everything together in the pan, cheese, herbs, off the heat.

640 KCAL **48 g** PROTEIN

Most protein of any meal here. The comfort-food day — proof that pasta was never the problem.

L8 Halloumi & Lentil Plate

15 MIN

YOU NEED

- 100 g halloumi (or *queso para freír*)
- 200 g cooked green or brown lentils, tinned is fine
- 1 tsp cumin · 2 cloves garlic · lemon · 1 tbsp olive oil
- Tomato, onion and parsley salad
- 1 small pita

METHOD

Lentils rinsed, then warmed through with the garlic, cumin and olive oil — 5 minutes, and finish with a lot of lemon.

Halloumi dry-fried, no oil, 2 minutes each side until it's properly dark. Don't move it while it colours.

Lentils down, halloumi on, salad beside, pita to scoop.

640 KCAL **38 g** PROTEIN

Lentils + lemon is a real trick, not a garnish: the vitamin C roughly doubles how much iron you absorb from the lentils.

ROTATE THE SPICE, NOT THE RECIPE

The fastest way to never get bored: cook the same 150 g of chicken and change one thing. Three minutes of thought, a completely different meal, and no new shopping.

- Baharat + yogurt + lemon → shawarma
- Harissa + tomato + garlic → Tunisian
- Sumac + onion + olive oil → musakhan
- Ras el hanout + preserved lemon → tagine

The same applies to the grain — rice, bulgur, freekeh, couscous and potatoes are interchangeable at equal cooked weight. And to the protein: chicken, beef, lamb, fish, halloumi and chickpeas all slot into any of these plates.

20:15 · 30 G PROTEIN · 15 MINUTES OR LESS

Dinner

Light, warm and small — but never skipped and never protein-free. Eating a real dinner is what lets you sleep properly and wake up able to eat breakfast. Three of the eight below need no cooking at all.

D1 Chorba Frik

20 MIN · MAKES 2

YOU NEED

- 120 g lamb or chicken, cut very small
- 40 g frik (green wheat) or orzo
- 1 onion · 1 stick celery · 1 tbsp tomato purée
- Tabil or cumin + coriander · a pinch of cinnamon
- Parsley, coriander, and lemon at the end

METHOD

Meat and onion in the pot with a little oil until coloured. Tomato purée, spices, 1 minute — cooking the purée is what removes the tinny taste.

Water or stock, frik in, 15 minutes at a lazy simmer.

Herbs and a hard squeeze of lemon *off* the heat. The second portion is tomorrow's dinner and it will be better.

420 KCAL **32 g** PROTEIN

The one exception to "no meal prep": it makes two and improves overnight. Cook it Sunday and Wednesday and two dinners are solved.

D2 Shorbet Adas + Eggs

20 MIN

YOU NEED

- 80 g red lentils
- 1 onion · 1 tsp cumin · ½ tsp turmeric · 1 clove garlic
- 600 ml stock
- 2 eggs, boiled
- Lemon · olive oil · toasted pita, broken

METHOD

Onion softened, spices in for a minute, lentils and stock, 15 minutes with the lid on.

Blend it smooth — a stick blender straight in the pot, no extra washing up.

Lemon, a thread of olive oil, pita chips on top. The two eggs on the side are what take it from 15 g of protein to 28.

430 KCAL **28 g** PROTEIN

Lentil soup alone is a carb meal, not a dinner. The eggs are the point — never serve it without them.

D3 Omelette Blanche & Big Salad

8 MIN

YOU NEED

- 3 whole eggs + 1 extra white
- 2 handfuls spinach · 25 g feta · dill and parsley
- 1 tsp olive oil
- Tomato, cucumber and onion salad, lemon and olive oil

METHOD

Spinach wilted in the dry pan first, 1 minute, then tipped out — otherwise it waters down the eggs.

Oil, beaten eggs, low heat, lid on for 4 minutes. Spinach, feta and herbs over one half, fold.

The salad should be bigger than the omelette. That's the ratio that makes a light dinner feel like a meal.

400 KCAL **31 g** PROTEIN

Eight minutes, one pan, and you always have the ingredients. This is the dinner for the night you get home late and annoyed.

D4 Grilled Chicken Fattoush**12 MIN****YOU NEED**

- 130 g chicken breast
- 1 tsp sumac · garlic · lemon · salt · ½ tsp olive oil
- Romaine, tomato, cucumber, radish, spring onion, mint, parsley
- ½ pita, toasted
- Dressing: olive oil, lemon, sumac, pomegranate molasses if you have it

METHOD

Flatten the breast with your palm so it cooks evenly, season, hot dry pan, 4 minutes a side. Let it rest two minutes before slicing or the juice ends up on the board.

Salad dressed hard, chicken sliced over it, broken pita last.

420 KCAL **38 g** PROTEIN

The highest-protein dinner in the book, and the lightest-feeling. Good on Pilates evenings.

D5 The Labneh Mezze Plate ★**5 MIN · NO COOKING****YOU NEED**

- 150 g labneh, or thick Greek yogurt
- Olive oil + za'atar, generously
- 2 boiled eggs (from the batch in the fridge)
- Olives, cucumber, tomato, radish, mint, pickled turnip
- 1 small pita

METHOD

Labneh spread across a plate with the back of a spoon, a well in the middle, olive oil poured in, za'atar over the whole thing.

Everything else arranged around it. This isn't cooking, it's assembly — which is exactly why it's here.

430 KCAL **28 g** PROTEIN

Zero heat, zero washing up, five minutes. There is no evening too tired for this one — which means there is no evening you skip dinner.

D6 Baked White Fish & Loubia**18 MIN****YOU NEED**

- 160 g cod, hake or any white fish
- 250 g green beans, fresh or frozen
- 2 tomatoes or ½ tin · 3 cloves garlic · 1 tbsp olive oil
- Cumin · coriander leaf · lemon

METHOD

Beans, tomato, garlic, cumin and oil in a covered pan on low — 15 minutes, until the beans are properly soft, not squeaky. This is the whole dish; don't rush it.

Fish seasoned and laid on top for the last 7 minutes, lid back on. Coriander and lemon at the table.

380 KCAL **35 g** PROTEIN

Lowest-calorie dinner here, so it's the one to use on a day lunch ran big or you ate out. One pan, no oven.

D7 Light Menemen**10 MIN****YOU NEED**

- 3 eggs
- 1 green pepper · 2 tomatoes, skinned and chopped
- 1 tsp pepper paste (*biber salçası*) or harissa
- 1 tsp olive oil · Aleppo pepper · salt
- 1 slice bread · 30 g white cheese on the side

METHOD

Pepper in the oil on medium, 4 minutes, until it gives up. Tomato and paste, 3 minutes, until the water has gone and it looks glossy.

Eggs beaten and poured in, then stirred slowly and taken off while still soft. Aleppo pepper over the top.

420 KCAL **28 g** PROTEIN

The difference between good and bad menemen is entirely in how long you cook the tomatoes down. Give them the full three minutes.

D8 Cottage Cheese & Smoked Salmon Plate**4 MIN · NO COOKING****YOU NEED**

- 150 g cottage cheese or *queso fresco batido*
- 80 g smoked salmon
- Cucumber, dill, spring onion, capers
- Lemon · black pepper · olive oil
- 2 rye crackers or 1 slice rye bread

METHOD

There is no method. Put it on a plate. Lemon and a lot of black pepper over everything, dill torn on top.

Four minutes, 36 g of protein, nothing to wash but a plate.

390 KCAL **36 g** PROTEIN

Keep a pack of smoked salmon in the freezer. It defrosts in twenty minutes and turns any hopeless evening into a real dinner.

WHY DINNER IS THE SMALL MEAL

Not because eating at night makes you fat — it doesn't. Because your appetite is largest at 13:00 when you get home, and because a lighter evening meal means you actually wake up hungry, which is what makes breakfast possible. The calories have to go somewhere; this is simply the arrangement that fits your day. **Light is not the same as absent.** 30 g of protein, every night.

STILL HUNGRY AFTER DINNER?

First, drink 300 ml of water and wait ten minutes — thirst reads as hunger far more often than people believe. Still hungry? Then eat: a yogurt, a piece of fruit, more salad, another egg. Real hunger after a 1,700 kcal day is information, not weakness. It usually means lunch was too small or you missed the afternoon snack. Fix that tomorrow rather than going to bed hungry tonight.

17:30 & AFTER DINNER

Snacks & the sweet fix

Snacking is *part of the plan*, not a failure of it. A planned snack at 17:30 is the difference between a calm dinner and standing at the fridge at 22:00. Everything below is already inside your daily budget.

AFTERNOON · 17:30

OPTION	KCAL	PROTEIN	NOTES
150 g Greek yogurt + 2 dates	180	15 g	The best all-round choice — protein, sweetness and it holds you until 20:15.
1 orange + 12 almonds	160	5 g	Portable. Keep a bag of almonds in your room, not the kitchen.
Apple + 1 tsp peanut butter	150	4 g	One <i>level</i> teaspoon. Peanut butter is the easiest 300 kcal in any kitchen.
20 g dark chocolate 70 %	120	2 g	Two squares, with mint tea, sitting down. Not from the packet standing up.
20 g popcorn, air-popped	80	3 g	Paprika and salt. Enormous volume for almost nothing — good on a hungry day.
Frozen berries + skyr + honey	170	14 g	Stirred together it goes thick and cold, like frozen yogurt.
Protein mhalabia	200	25 g	200 g Greek yogurt + ½ scoop vanilla whey + a few drops of rose water + chopped pistachios. Stir hard. It sets like a dessert and it is the single most useful recipe on this page.

THE RULE FOR ANYTHING SWEET

Put it on a plate, sit down, and eat it slowly with tea. Nothing is forbidden — including baklava at your family's table, including chocolate on a bad day. What ruins a week isn't the sweet thing; it's eating it standing at the counter, not enjoying it, and then deciding the day is "ruined" and skipping dinner. **Eat it on purpose and the day is still perfect.**

TWO THINGS THAT QUIETLY COST 400 KCAL

- **Flavoured coffee.** A large caramel latte or frappuccino is a meal's worth of calories with three grams of protein. *Café con leche*, always.
- **Oil poured by eye.** Olive oil is excellent and it is also 90 kcal a tablespoon. Measure it with a spoon for two weeks until your hand learns the amount, then stop measuring.

FREE, UNLIMITED, ANY TIME

Water · sparkling water with lemon · mint tea · green tea · black coffee · herbal tea · cucumber, tomato, radish, celery, lettuce, peppers · lemon, garlic, herbs and every spice in the kit. If you are genuinely hungry between meals and it isn't snack time, start here.

PUT TOGETHER

Three days, start to finish

So you can see what it actually looks like. Copy these three for the first week and you won't have to make a single decision.

Day A • Pilates day

10,000 STEPS

06:15	B1 Express Shakshuka	455	27 g	Coffee after
10:00	Skyr pot + almonds	210	20 g	Packed last night
13:15	L1 Chicken Shawarma Bowl	640	46 g	The big one
16:30	Pilates, 60 min	—	—	Heavier springs
17:45	Greek yogurt + 2 dates	180	15 g	Straight after class
20:15	D4 Grilled Chicken Fattoush	420	38 g	Light, fast
Total		1,905	146 g	Phase 1

Day B • Long study day, no class at the studio

7,000 STEPS

06:15	B3 Two-Minute Yogurt Bowl	440	28 g	Two minutes
10:00	2 boiled eggs + apple	230	13 g	From the batch
13:15	L6 Tuna Fattoush Plus	600	45 g	No cooking
17:30	Orange + 12 almonds	160	5 g	At the desk
20:15	D2 Shorbet Adas + 2 eggs	430	28 g	Warm and easy
21:15	20 g dark chocolate + mint tea	120	2 g	Planned
Total		1,980	121 g	Phase 1

Day C • Family lunch, and you're not cooking it

10,000 STEPS

08:30	B2 Labneh, za'atar & egg toast	470	30 g	Weekend timing
14:00	Whatever is cooked — a normal plate, meat first, one round of bread	≈ 800	≈ 40 g	Enjoy it properly
18:00	Long walk · fruit	80	1 g	The walk matters more
21:00	D8 Cottage cheese & smoked salmon plate	390	36 g	Deliberately light
Total		≈ 1,740	≈ 107 g	Still on target

Read Day C carefully. A big family lunch does not need fixing. You keep breakfast, you keep dinner, you make the evening meal a light one, and the day lands exactly where it should. What breaks a program is skipping dinner to "make up for" lunch — that is the old habit, wearing a new excuse.

THE ONLY NUMBER WORTH KNOWING

Protein cheat sheet

Screenshot this page. You don't need to count calories — but you do need a feel for protein, because it is the one thing that decides whether the weight you lose comes off your fat or off your muscle. **Target: 120 g a day.**

MEAT, FISH & EGGS	PORTION	PROTEIN
Chicken breast	150 g raw	33 g
Chicken thigh, boneless	150 g raw	27 g
Beef mince, 5 % fat	150 g raw	30 g
Lamb, lean	150 g raw	28 g
Merguez (halal)	100 g	15 g
Turkey slices	60 g	12 g
Cod / hake	150 g	27 g
Salmon	150 g	30 g
Smoked salmon	80 g	18 g
Tuna, tinned, drained	80 g	20 g
Egg, large	1	6.5 g

DAIRY	PORTION	PROTEIN
Skyr	150 g	17 g
Greek yogurt 2 %	200 g	18 g
Cottage cheese / <i>queso batido</i>	150 g	18 g
Labneh	100 g	9 g
Halloumi	100 g	22 g
Feta	30 g	4.5 g
Milk, semi-skimmed	250 ml	8 g
Whey powder	1 scoop / 30 g	24 g

PLANTS	PORTION	PROTEIN
Lentils, cooked	200 g	18 g
Chickpeas, tinned	240 g	17 g
Pistachios	30 g	6 g
Almonds	20 g	4 g
Tahini	15 g	3 g
Bulgur / rice, cooked	150 g	4–6 g
Wholemeal pita	60 g	5 g

THE 30-GRAM TEST

Before you eat anything, ask one question: *where are my 30 grams?* If you can't point at them on the plate, add an egg, a yogurt, a tin of tuna or a scoop of whey. That single habit is worth more than every other page in this document.

ONE BIG SHOP, ONE SMALL MID-WEEK TOP-UP

The weekly shopping list

Everything here is in Mercadona, Lidl, Carrefour, Dia or Alcampo except the halal meat and the spices — those are on page 21. Spanish names are in *italics* so you can point at a shelf instead of reading every label.

FRIDGE · EVERY WEEK

- ☐ Eggs × 18–24 *huevos* — you'll use about 15
- ☐ Greek yogurt, 1 kg tub *yogur griego natural*
- ☐ Skyr × 6 pots *Hacendado / Milbona Skyr*
- ☐ Cottage cheese × 2 *queso fresco batido 0 % / requesón*
- ☐ Feta × 1 *queso feta*
- ☐ Halloumi × 1 *queso para freír*
- ☐ Semi-skimmed milk, 2 L *leche semidesnatada*
- ☐ Hummus × 2 pots
- ☐ Labneh, if you find it — otherwise strain Greek yogurt in a cloth overnight

PROTEIN COUNTER · HALAL

- ☐ Chicken breast + thigh, 1 kg total *pechuga / muslo de pollo*
- ☐ Beef mince 5 % fat, 500 g *carne picada de ternera 5 %*
- ☐ Merguez or halal chicken sausage × 1 pack
- ☐ Lamb for chorba, 250 g *cordero* — optional
- ☐ Turkey slices, halal-certified *pavo*

FISH COUNTER

- ☐ Salmon × 2 fillets *salmón*
- ☐ Cod or hake × 2 *bacalao / merluza* — frozen is fine and cheaper
- ☐ Smoked salmon × 1 pack *salmón ahumado* — keep it in the freezer

CUPBOARD · RESTOCK MONTHLY

- ☐ Crushed tomato × 4 tins *tomate triturado*
- ☐ Chickpeas × 3 tins *garbanzos cocidos*
- ☐ Lentils, cooked × 2 tins *lentejas cocidas*
- ☐ Red lentils, 500 g *lentejas rojas*
- ☐ Tuna in olive oil × 6 *atún en aceite de oliva*
- ☐ Bulgur, freekeh or couscous *bulgur / cuscús*
- ☐ Basmati rice *arroz basmati*
- ☐ Wholewheat pasta *pasta integral*
- ☐ Oats, 1 kg *copos de avena*
- ☐ Extra virgin olive oil *aceite de oliva virgen extra*
- ☐ Tahini *tahina*
- ☐ Tomato purée *concentrado de tomate*
- ☐ Honey *miel*
- ☐ Medjool dates *dátiles*
- ☐ Almonds, walnuts, pistachios — raw, unsalted *crudos, sin sal*
- ☐ Peanut butter, 100 % peanuts
- ☐ Dark chocolate 70–85 % *chocolate negro*
- ☐ Olives and capers *aceitunas, alcaparras*
- ☐ Popcorn kernels *maíz para palomitas*

BREAD · BUY ONCE, FREEZE HALF

- ☐ Wholemeal pita × 1 pack *pan de pita integral*
- ☐ Rye or wholemeal bread *pan de centeno / integral*
- ☐ Wholemeal tortillas *tortillas de trigo integral*

FREEZE THE BREAD THE DAY YOU BUY IT

Slice it first. It toasts straight from frozen, it never goes stale, and it removes the most common reason a good breakfast doesn't happen: there was no bread.

PRODUCE · BUY TWICE A WEEK

Sunday and Wednesday. Small amounts, bought fresh — that's the whole reason you don't need meal prep.

- ☐ Tomatoes, 1 kg *tomates*
- ☐ Cucumbers × 4 *pepinos*
- ☐ Red onions × 4, white onions × 4 *cebollas*
- ☐ Garlic, 2 heads *ajo*
- ☐ Lemons × 8 — you will use every one *limones*
- ☐ Green peppers × 4 *pimientos verdes*
- ☐ Romaine lettuce × 2 *lechuga romana*
- ☐ Radishes, spring onions *rábanos, cebolleta*
- ☐ Carrots *zanahorias*
- ☐ Flat parsley, mint, coriander, dill *perejil, hierbabuena, cilantro, eneldo*
- ☐ Spinach *espinacas*
- ☐ Green beans *judías verdes*
- ☐ Potatoes *patatas*
- ☐ Bananas, apples, oranges, pears

FREEZER

- ☐ Berries *frutos rojos congelados*
- ☐ Spinach *espinacas congeladas*
- ☐ Green beans *judías verdes congeladas*
- ☐ White fish fillets *filetes de merluza*
- ☐ Half the bread, sliced

THE EMERGENCY SHELF

Five things that must never run out. As long as these are in the flat, there is no such thing as "there was nothing to eat":

- Tinned tuna
- Tinned chickpeas
- Eggs
- Olive oil & lemons
- Whey powder

Tuna + chickpeas + olive oil + lemon + parsley is a four-minute meal with 40 g of protein. That is the floor of this entire program, and it costs about €2.

WHAT A WEEK COSTS

Halal meat & fish	€22–28
Dairy & eggs	€14–17
Produce	€12–15
Cupboard (averaged)	€8–10
Whey (averaged)	€5–6
Per week	€61–76

Roughly €9–11 a day for five eating occasions. Cheaper than eating badly, and far cheaper than a single meal out in Madrid.

TWO HABITS WORTH MORE THAN ANY LIST

- **Never shop hungry.** Go after lunch, not at 20:00 on the way home.
- **Buy the protein first.** Fill the basket from the meat, fish and dairy counters before you go anywhere near the aisles. What you buy first is what you eat.

ONE TRIP · ABOUT €30 · LASTS MONTHS

The flavour kit

This is the page that decides whether you're still doing this in week twelve. Nothing in this program is bland, because nothing in this program is unseasoned. Buy all of it once and you will never cook a boring plate again.

TUNISIAN

- **Harissa** — the backbone. Paste, in a jar or tube.
- **Tabil** — coriander, caraway, garlic, chilli.
- **Caraway seed**
- **Ras el hanout**
- **Preserved lemon**
- **Capers & olives**

SYRIAN & LEVANTINE

- **Baharat / 7-spice** — the shawarma smell.
- **Za'atar** — for labneh and bread.
- **Sumac** — sour, red, on everything.
- **Aleppo pepper** filfil halabi
- **Pomegranate molasses**
- **Dried mint · Rose water**

EVERYDAY

- Cumin, ground *and* seed
- Sweet and smoked paprika
- Coriander seed
- Cinnamon · Turmeric
- Black pepper, in a grinder
- Flaky salt
- Bay leaves

Where to buy it in Madrid

MIDDLE-EASTERN & NORTH AFRICAN GROCERS

Lavapiés — Calle del Oso, Calle Embajadores and the surrounding streets. The densest concentration of Arab and Moroccan grocers in the city, and the cheapest spices by a wide margin.

Tetuán — along and around Calle Bravo Murillo. Several halal butchers and grocers within a few hundred metres of each other.

Usera and **Villaverde** — good for bulk pulses, rice and nuts.

HALAL MEAT

Look for a *carnicería halal* — Lavapiés and Tetuán both have several, and most neighbourhoods in Madrid have at least one. Buy for the week and freeze in portions on the day you buy.

Carrefour and **Alcampo** carry halal sections in a number of their larger Madrid stores, and stock harissa, tahini and couscous in the international aisle year-round.

Mercadona is excellent for dairy, eggs, fish and produce, but does not reliably stock halal meat — plan on buying meat elsewhere.

CHECK THE LABEL, NOT THE PICTURE

Spanish charcuterie is overwhelmingly pork, and pork appears in places you wouldn't expect it. Words to watch for: *cerdo, jamón, chorizo, lomo, panceta, bacon, morcilla, salchichón, manteca de cerdo, gelatina*. Some gummy sweets, some yogurts and some protein bars contain pork gelatin — when in doubt, check for *gelatina bovina* or choose a product with a halal mark.

3 × 60 MINUTES A WEEK

Pilates — how to make it build muscle

Pilates absolutely can build muscle, but only if it is treated as resistance training rather than as a stretching class. The difference is entirely in how hard the last few repetitions are. Here is how to get the most out of the three hours a week you have.

THE WEEK

Monday	Pilates · 60 min	10,000 steps
Tuesday	Rest	6–8,000
Wednesday	Pilates · 60 min	10,000 steps
Thursday	Rest	6–8,000
Friday	Rest	6–8,000
Saturday	Pilates · 60 min	10,000 steps
Sunday	Rest · long walk	6–8,000

Shift the days to fit your timetable — what matters is three classes and at least one rest day between two of them, not which day they fall on.

SIX RULES FOR THE STUDIO

- **Reformer over mat**, whenever you have the choice. Springs give you something to progress against; your own body weight doesn't.
- **Ask for heavier springs**. Tell the instructor your goal is strength, not "toning". They will adjust the class for you — this is a normal request.
- **The last 2–3 reps should be genuinely hard**. Legs shaking is not a problem, it is the entire point. If a set is comfortable all the way through, it built nothing.
- **Progress the load, not the reps**. Doing thirty easy repetitions is cardio. Doing ten hard ones is training.
- **Slow the lowering phase**. Three seconds down on everything. This is free extra stimulus and it costs no equipment.
- **Ankle weights or a band** in mat classes, if the studio allows it. 1–2 kg changes everything on leg and glute work.

NEVER GO TO CLASS FASTED

Breakfast and the mid-morning snack are compulsory on class days. Training with an empty tank is exactly how you lose muscle instead of building it — the body has no fuel and no amino acids available, so it takes both from the tissue you are trying to keep. If class lands after 17:30, eat the afternoon snack first.

PROTEIN AROUND THE CLASS

Within roughly two hours either side — and the window is genuinely that wide, so don't stress about it. In practice: lunch at 13:15 before a 16:30 class, and the yogurt or shake straight after. The class is the *signal* to build; the protein is the *material*. One without the other does nothing.

WHAT YOU WILL FEEL, AND WHEN

Weeks 1–3

Sore in new places. Classes feel harder than before — that's because you finally have the energy to work properly.

Weeks 4–8

Springs go up. Exercises that used to be impossible become merely hard. Balance and control improve visibly.

Weeks 9–16

Visible definition — shoulders, back, glutes. This is the muscle you were losing, coming back.

THE QUIET ENGINE

Steps

Over a week, walking will burn considerably more than your three Pilates classes combined — and unlike hard cardio, it costs you no recovery and barely raises your appetite. This is the most underrated part of the entire program.

10k

3 DAYS A WEEK

6–8k

THE OTHER 4 DAYS

58k

WEEKLY TOTAL

2,200 kcal

BURNED PER WEEK

How to hit them without ever “going for a walk”

DO THIS	STEPS GAINED	COSTS YOU
Get off the metro one stop early, morning and evening	+3,000	8 minutes
Walk the last stretch home from uni instead of the bus	+2,500	15 minutes
A 25-minute walk after dinner	+2,500	25 minutes — and it helps digestion and sleep
Stairs instead of the lift, always	+400	Nothing
Take your phone calls standing and walking	+3,000	Nothing at all
Do the food shop on foot, twice a week	+2,000	Nothing — you were going anyway

STEPS HAPPEN ON PILATES DAYS TOO

They are not exercise — they are the background of your day. A Pilates class is not a reason to sit still for the other fifteen hours. In fact the 10,000-step days are best placed *on* class days, because you're already out of the house.

WHAT NOT TO ADD

- **No running, no HIIT, no extra cardio.**
- It would eat into recovery from Pilates, sharply raise your appetite, and add stress to a body that has been under-fuelled for a long time.
- The deficit comes from food. The muscle comes from Pilates and protein. The rest comes from walking. That is the whole machine, and adding cardio breaks it rather than speeding it up.

IF YOU ONLY CHANGE ONE THING THIS WEEK

Walk for twenty-five minutes after dinner, every night. It is 2,500 steps, it settles digestion, it drops evening cortisol, it makes you fall asleep faster, and it is the easiest habit in this document to keep for sixteen weeks. Put your headphones on and call someone.

TWO THINGS. NOT TEN.

Supplements

You've never taken any, and you don't need many. Two are genuinely useful here; a third depends on a blood test. Everything else in a supplement shop is a waste of money.

1 • Whey protein

THE MAIN TOOL

WHY

Going from roughly 40 g of protein a day to 120 g is a big jump, and while your appetite is still small, food alone won't get you there. One scoop is 24 g in thirty seconds, no cooking and no appetite required. It is powdered milk protein — that is all it is.

HOW

- **Dose:** one scoop (~30 g) a day. Two on a heavy day.
- **When:** whichever meal is lightest — usually the mid-morning snack, or breakfast on a rushed morning, or straight after Pilates.
- **Which:** plain concentrate or isolate, vanilla or chocolate. Look for a halal mark and check the ingredients for gelatin — HSN, Prozis and MyProtein all list halal-certified lines and deliver across Spain in a day or two.
- **Cost:** about €25–30 per kg — 33 servings, roughly €0.80 a day.
- **If it upsets your stomach:** switch to isolate, which is far lower in lactose.

2 • Vitamin D3

1,000–2,000 IU DAILY

You leave at 07:20 and you're indoors from 08:00 to 12:00 — most of the useful daylight, especially between October and March. Low vitamin D is very common in students and presents as exactly what you've been describing: tired, flat, slow to recover, low mood. Take it with a meal containing fat; breakfast with eggs is ideal. Any *farmacia* sells it over the counter and a year's supply costs under €15.

3 • Iron — only if a blood test says so

DO NOT SELF-PRESCRIBE

Low ferritin is the most common reason a twenty-year-old woman feels exhausted, and it is very easy to fix — *once it has been measured*. Supplementing iron you don't need is genuinely harmful, so this one needs a number, not a guess.

If the fatigue hasn't lifted after four weeks of eating properly, ask a GP for **ferritin, full blood count, vitamin D, B12 and TSH**. Meanwhile the food does a lot of the work — L3, L8 and D2, always with lemon.

WHAT TO SKIP

Fat burners, detox teas, "slimming" infusions, CLA, L-carnitine, appetite suppressants, collagen for weight loss. None of them work, several aren't halal-certified, and some sold online are genuinely unsafe. Creatine is the one other supplement with real evidence behind it, but it isn't a priority for you now.

THE PART NOBODY WRITES DOWN

Energy, sleep & water

You said the thing that bothers you most is having no energy. Food fixes most of it — but these four habits fix the rest, and they're free.

WATER · 2–2.5 LITRES

06:00	500 ml, before coffee, before the phone
07:15	Fill the bottle for class
08–12	1 litre across the morning
Afternoon	500 ml
Evening	300 ml + herbal tea

A visible bottle on the desk is worth more than any reminder app. Mild dehydration reads as tiredness, headache and hunger — and it is almost certainly part of your 11 a.m. slump.

CAFFEINE

- **One or two coffees a day, both before 14:00.** Caffeine has a half-life of about six hours — a 17:00 coffee is still a third in your system at 23:00, wrecking the sleep that's meant to be rebuilding you.
- **Never on an empty stomach.** Coffee before food causes exactly the shaky, slightly nauseous feeling that then makes breakfast impossible. Eat first, coffee second — this one change alone will help.
- **Not a replacement for food.** Coffee borrows energy; it doesn't create it, and it has been covering for meals you weren't eating.

SLEEP · 7.5 HOURS

A 06:00 alarm means lights out at **22:30**. Not negotiable, because almost everything this program is trying to do happens while you're asleep: muscle repair, hormone reset, appetite regulation.

- Screens down at 21:45
- Phone charging across the room, not by the pillow
- Room dark and cool
- Last coffee before 14:00
- The after-dinner walk makes falling asleep noticeably easier

Short sleep raises hunger hormones, lowers willpower and reduces how much muscle you build from the same class. It is not a small lever.

THE 3 P.M. CRASH

It is not normal, it is not your personality, and it is not something to solve with more coffee. It is a blood sugar and fuel problem caused by eating too little too late in the day.

It should disappear within about ten days of eating breakfast, a mid-morning snack and a real lunch. That is one of the first and clearest signs the program is working.

If it is still there after four weeks of genuinely eating three meals a day — that's the blood test on page 27. Don't wait longer than that.

THE ORDER THINGS COME BACK IN

You will not feel different on day one, and that is normal. This is roughly the sequence people experience, and knowing it in advance is what gets you through week two:

- **Days 3–10** — the afternoon crash fades
- **Week 2–3** — real morning hunger returns
- **Week 3–4** — deeper sleep, better skin, warmer hands
- **Week 4–6** — clothes change before the scale does
- **Week 6–10** — visible definition, heavier springs
- **Week 10–16** — the number on the scale

HONEST, SHORT, IMPORTANT

Health notes

THE MORNING-AFTER PILL YOU TOOK FOUR DAYS AGO

Tiredness, nausea, headache, sore breasts and light spotting are all common, well-documented side effects, and they usually settle within a few days to a couple of weeks — so some of the exhaustion you're feeling right now has nothing to do with your diet. Two practical consequences for this program:

- **Ignore the scale for the next ten to fourteen days.** Hormonal water retention can easily add one to two kilos that has nothing whatsoever to do with fat. Weighing yourself during this window will only upset you over nothing.
- **Your next period may arrive early or late** — up to about a week either way is expected. If it is more than seven days later than you'd expect, take a pregnancy test, because the pill reduces the chance of pregnancy but does not eliminate it.

Start the program now anyway. Eating properly will help the fatigue, not add to it.

YOUR CYCLE, AND HOW TO WORK WITH IT

- **The week before your period:** appetite up, water weight up, mood down. This is when programs get abandoned. The plan: keep protein high, eat the carbs without guilt, and *do not weigh yourself*. It passes in four days.
- **During your period:** you lose iron. Prioritise L3 (kefta), L8 (lentils) and D2, always with lemon — vitamin C roughly doubles iron absorption. Keep going to Pilates unless you're in real pain; gentle movement genuinely helps cramps.
- **If your periods are irregular, very light, or have stopped:** that is a signal that your body has been under-fuelled for a long time. It is a reason to eat *more*, not less — and a reason to see a doctor rather than wait it out.

SEE A DOCTOR IF — NOT OPTIONAL

- The fatigue hasn't clearly improved after **four weeks** of eating three real meals a day.
- Dizziness when you stand up, hair falling out more than usual, feeling cold all the time, nails breaking, bruising easily.
- Periods that stop for three months or more.
- Heart racing at rest, or breathlessness on stairs you used to manage easily.
- Food starts to feel like anxiety rather than fuel — talk to someone about that early, not late. It is far more common than people admit, and it is very treatable.

THE BLOOD TEST TO ASK FOR

If it comes to it, this is the panel. Write it down and hand it over — you don't have to explain yourself.

Ferritin · full blood count (hemograma) · vitamin D · vitamin B12 · folate · TSH and free T4 · coeliac screen

WHERE, IN MADRID

A *centro de salud* GP appointment is free with a health card, and students from the EU can use a European Health Insurance Card. Your university will also have a student health service.

If you'd rather not wait, private labs — Synlab, Unilabs, Cerba — will run a panel like the one above without a referral for roughly €40–70.

A note on what this document is. This is nutrition and lifestyle guidance written for a healthy twenty-year-old with no known medical conditions, no allergies and no medication. It is not medical advice and it is not a substitute for seeing a doctor. If anything here conflicts with what a doctor tells you, the doctor wins.

SIXTEEN WEEKS

The roadmap

Slow on purpose. A 250 kcal deficit with 120 g of protein and three resistance sessions a week is the combination that takes fat off while *adding* muscle. Faster than this and you start paying for it in muscle, energy and your period.

WEEKS	PHASE	CALORIES	PROTEIN	PILATES	EXPECTED WEIGHT	THE GOAL OF THIS BLOCK
1-3	Refuel	1,900	115 g	2-3 ×	59 → 59.5 kg	Three meals a day, twenty-one days running. The scale is <i>not</i> the target — it may rise, and that's water.
4-7	Reshape I	1,700	120 g	3 ×	59 → 58 kg	The deficit begins. Energy should be clearly better than in week 1. Waist starts moving.
8-11	Reshape II	1,700	120 g	3 ×	58 → 56.8 kg	The steady middle. Springs go up in class. This is where visible change starts.
12-15	Reshape III	1,700	120 g	3 ×	56.8 → 55.5 kg	Hold the line. Don't cut further and don't add cardio — just keep doing exactly this.
16 +	Hold	1,850–1,950	120 g	3 ×	≈ 55 kg	Calories come back up to maintenance. Protein and Pilates stay. This is how the result stays.

WEEK 16 IS NOT THE FINISH LINE

It's the point where you stop losing and start *maintaining* — eating around 1,900 kcal, still with 120 g of protein, still at Pilates three times a week. Almost everyone who regains weight does it because they treated the end of the diet as the end of the habits. The habits are the result; the weight is just a side effect of them.

READ THE WEIGHT COLUMN LOOSELY

Those numbers are a trend line, not a schedule. Real weeks go: down 0.6, up 0.2, flat, down 0.5. Two flat weeks in a row is normal and means nothing. What matters is the direction across a month — and, far more than the scale, what the tape measure around your waist is doing.

THREE WAYS THIS GOES WRONG — ALL AVOIDABLE

Skipping Phase 1

Going straight into a deficit from a starved baseline. You lose muscle, your energy never recovers, and you stall by week five.

Cutting harder when it slows

The instinct that got you here. Below 1,600 kcal the body defends itself and the whole thing grinds to a halt.

Quitting in the flat month

There will be a stretch where the scale barely moves while your waist drops. That's muscle replacing fat. Keep going.

MEASURE THE RIGHT THINGS

How to track progress

You are going to build muscle while losing fat. That means there will be a month where the scale barely moves and your waist drops three centimetres. If the scale is the only thing you measure, you will quit during exactly that month. Don't let that happen.

WEEKLY · SATURDAY MORNING

Same day, same time, after the bathroom, before eating or drinking, same clothes or none.

1. **Weight.** Write it down — but only the *four-week trend* means anything. A single reading is noise.
2. **Waist,** at the navel, tape flat, don't pull it tight, don't hold your breath in. This is the number that matters most.
3. **Hips,** at the widest point.
4. **Photos** every two weeks — front and side, same spot, same light, same time of day. You will not notice change day to day. You will absolutely notice it between photo one and photo six.

DAILY · TEN SECONDS IN A NOTES APP

Five ticks. That's the whole system.

- Three meals? **Yes / No**
- Protein target? **Yes / No**
- Steps
- Energy, out of 10
- Hours slept

After four weeks this little log is more useful than any app, because when something stalls you can look back and see immediately which of the five slipped. It is nearly always one of the first two.

The wins to watch for, in the order they arrive

WHEN	WHAT CHANGES	WHY IT MATTERS
Week 1–2	The 3 p.m. crash stops	The first proof that the fuel, not your willpower, was the problem.
Week 2–3	You're genuinely hungry at mealtimes	The clearest single sign that your metabolism is waking back up.
Week 3–4	Deeper sleep · better skin · warmer hands	Your body has stopped rationing. These are the first visible knock-on effects.
Week 4–6	Clothes fit differently before the scale moves	Fat leaving and muscle arriving. The tape measure will confirm it.
Week 6–10	Visible definition · heavier springs in class	Direct evidence you're building, not just shrinking.
Week 10–16	The number on the scale	It arrives last. It always arrives last.

DO NOT WEIGH YOURSELF EVERY DAY

Daily weight swings by up to 1.5 kg from salt, water, carbs, hormones, hydration and how full your gut is — none of which is fat. Gaining a kilo of actual fat would require eating about 7,700 kcal above your maintenance. You did not do that overnight. Once a week, Saturday, and then put the scale away.

WHEN IT GETS HARD

Troubleshooting

Every one of these will happen at some point in sixteen weeks. None of them is a reason to stop.

“I’m never hungry in the morning.”

Completely expected, and temporary — your hunger signalling has gone quiet because you’ve trained it to. Don’t force a full plate. Use **B6, the 90-second shake**, for the first five days; liquid asks nothing of your appetite. Then move to B3, then to the cooked breakfasts. And stop drinking coffee before food — it is suppressing what little appetite you have. Real morning hunger usually returns within two weeks.

“I don’t have time to cook.”

Nothing in this document takes more than 25 minutes, and half of it takes under ten. **D5** (5 min), **D8** (4 min), **L6** (10 min) and **B3** (2 min) involve no cooking at all. On the very worst day: tuna, tinned chickpeas, olive oil, lemon, parsley, bread. Four minutes, 40 g of protein, and it is a complete meal — not a compromise.

“I skipped a meal.”

Then eat the next one normally. That is the entire answer. Do *not* eat less later to balance it out — that is the exact loop that created this problem. A missed meal is a missed meal, not a debt to be repaid.

“I ate way too much / there was a big family meal.”

Good. Enjoy it fully, and go back to normal at the very next meal — see Day C on page 17. One large meal cannot undo a week; it isn’t mathematically possible. Under-eating for three days afterwards to “fix” it absolutely can, because that’s three days of no protein, no energy and a signal to your body that food is scarce again.

“The scale went up.”

Run through the list: more salt than usual, more carbs than usual, period due, trained yesterday, constipated, drank less water, or — most likely in your first month — you’ve just started eating properly again and your muscles are refilling with glycogen and water. Every one of those adds weight that is not fat. Weigh again in three days and look at the trend, not the reading.

“I’m bored of the food.”

Rotate the spice, not the recipe — page 12. The same 150 g of chicken becomes shawarma, Tunisian, musakhan or tagine depending on one jar. Three minutes of thought, no new shopping, an entirely different meal. And swap the grain: rice, bulgur, freekeh, couscous and potatoes are interchangeable.

“Someone cooked for me and I can’t control the portions.”

Eat it, and enjoy it. Take a normal plate, go to the protein first, take one round of bread rather than three, and don’t take a second helping automatically. Tunisian and Syrian home cooking was never the problem here — the problem was eating almost nothing at all. Refusing food at your family’s table to protect a calorie target is the wrong trade, every time.

“Pilates was cancelled this week.”

Change nothing about the food. Add 2,000 steps on that day and carry on. One missed class across sixteen weeks is statistical noise. Two missed weeks in a row is worth solving — find a second studio or a class at a different time so a cancellation never costs you the whole week.

“I’ve been stuck at the same weight for three weeks.”

First, check honestly, with the daily log in front of you: are you *actually* eating three meals? Are you *actually* hitting 120 g of protein? Are you *actually* getting the steps? Nine plateaus out of ten are one of those three, and the answer is to fix it rather than to eat less.

If all three are genuinely yes for three straight weeks, and the *waist* hasn’t moved either, then reduce by about 100 kcal — one less tablespoon of oil, or a slightly smaller grain portion at lunch. That’s it. **Never below 1,600.**

“It’s the week before my period and I want to eat everything.”

Because your body genuinely needs a little more then — this is physiology, not a failure of discipline. Keep the protein high, let yourself have the extra carbs, add the dark chocolate, and *do not weigh yourself*. It lasts about four days and then it’s gone. Fighting it costs more than it saves.

“I feel guilty when I eat.”

Read this slowly: at 59 kg and 1.60 m, eating 1,700–1,900 kcal a day, you are not overeating. You are eating the amount a healthy adult woman needs. The guilt is a habit your body learned during a long stretch of under-eating, and it will fade as regular eating becomes normal again. If it doesn’t fade — or if it gets louder — talk to someone about it. That is a real thing, it is common, and it is treatable.

“I’m exhausted and I’ve been doing everything right.”

Give it four full weeks of three meals a day. If the fatigue is still there after that, stop troubleshooting the diet and go and get the blood test on page 26 — ferritin, full blood count, vitamin D, B12, TSH. Some tiredness is a nutrition problem. Some of it is a number that needs measuring, and no amount of eating well will fix it on its own.

MADRID, WITHOUT THE MATHS

Eating out

You are twenty and you live in Madrid. You are going to eat out, and that is entirely fine — it only needs a default order so you don't have to think about it every time.

SHAWARMA & KEBAB

Lavapiés, Tetuán — and halal by default

Ask for a **plato** rather than a durum: meat, salad and a little rice instead of a huge wrap. Skip the chips and the soft drink. Extra garlic sauce is fine; it's mostly nothing. **Easily 45 g of protein.** This is the best fast food in the city for you.

POKE BOWLS & SALAD BARS

Poke House, Honest Greens

Double the protein — it's usually €2–3 and it doubles the point of the meal. Half rice, half greens. Avocado yes; creamy sauce *and* crispy onions *and* mango together, no. Pick one indulgence, not three.

A SPANISH MENÚ DEL DÍA

Starter: salad, gazpacho or vegetable soup. Main: anything *a la plancha* — *pollo*, *merluza*, *atún*, *ternera*. Dessert: fruit or yogurt. Avoid *jamón*, *chorizo*, *morcilla*, *panceta* and *bacon*, which rules out most of the *bocadillo* menu anyway.

BREAKFAST OR COFFEE OUT

Tostada con tomate plus a portion of *tortilla española* and a *café con leche* is a genuinely decent 25 g breakfast. Ask for an extra egg if they'll do it. Avoid the pastry case — a *napolitana* is 400 kcal and 5 g of protein.

SUPERMARKET LUNCH IN A HURRY

Rotisserie chicken (*pollo asado*, check it's halal or choose tinned tuna instead) + a bag of salad + a pot of hummus + a piece of fruit. About €6, 40 g of protein, no cooking, eaten on a bench. Better than most restaurant meals and a quarter of the price.

COFFEE SHOPS

Café con leche, not a frappuccino. A large flavoured or iced coffee can carry 350–450 kcal, almost all sugar, with two grams of protein — a meal's worth of calories that will leave you hungry an hour later.

THE ONLY RULE THAT MATTERS WHEN EATING OUT

Find the protein, and don't skip the meals around it. If lunch out was big, make dinner one of the light no-cook plates — D5 or D8. If lunch out was small and mostly bread, add a yogurt or a shake when you get home. Eating out is a normal part of a normal life; it only causes problems when it becomes a reason to skip everything else that day.

PRINT IT · SCREENSHOT IT · STICK IT ON THE FRIDGE

The weekly tracker

One tick per box. Five ticks a day is a perfect day. Five perfect days out of seven is a perfect week — the plan is built with the slack already in it.

WEEK OF _____	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
MEALS							
Breakfast · 30 g protein							
Mid-morning snack							
Lunch · 40 g protein							
Afternoon snack							
Dinner · 30 g protein							
DAILY TARGETS							
120 g protein							
2 litres of water							
Whey + vitamin D							
In bed by 22:30							
Walk after dinner							
MOVEMENT							
Pilates (3 this week)							
Steps — write the number							
HOW IT FELT							
Energy /10							
Hours slept							

SATURDAY MORNING

Weight _____ kg

Waist _____ cm

Hips _____ cm

Photos ☐ done

THIS WEEK'S WIN

Something that isn't a number.
Energy, sleep, a heavier spring in
class, a meal you didn't skip when
you would have before.

WHAT TO FIX NEXT WEEK

One thing only. Not five.

ONE LAST THING

Read this on the bad days

Panda — you are not lazy and your body is not broken.

It has been running on far too little for far too long, and it did the only sensible thing a body can do in that situation: it turned everything down, and it started taking apart the muscle you weren't feeding. That is why you're tired. That is why the scale stopped. That is why you're losing exactly the tissue you wanted to keep. All three complaints, one cause — and the cause is not that you lack discipline. It's that you haven't been eating.

So look back through these pages and notice what *isn't* in them. There is no forbidden list. There is bread, rice, pasta, potatoes, olive oil, merguez, halloumi, dates and dark chocolate. There is a whole page about spices, because food you don't enjoy is food you'll abandon by March. You already cook better than most people ever will. Nothing about how you cook needed fixing. The only things missing were **quantity** and **protein**.

The whole program, honestly, is four lines:

- Eat three times a day.
- Put protein in every one of them.
- Walk, and go to your Pilates.
- Sleep.

The other thirty-one pages are just the details — the menus so you never have to decide, the shopping list so you never run out, the troubleshooting so a bad day doesn't become a bad month.

The first three weeks will be the hardest, and they will feel like nothing is happening. You'll be eating more than you have in a year, the scale might go *up*, and every old instinct will tell you to cut back. Don't. That is precisely the stretch where the work is being done underneath — glycogen refilling, hormones settling, appetite waking up.

By week six you'll have your energy back, and you'll notice it first in the smallest way: three o'clock will arrive and you just won't crash.

By week sixteen you'll have the body you actually wanted — **built, not shrunk**.



You've got this.

Start tomorrow morning. Breakfast, 06:15, thirty grams of protein.
That single meal is the whole program starting.